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Date
31 August 2026

Special Report

Takeaways from 2026 DB Tech Conference

Melissa Weathers
Research Analyst
+1-212-250-2134

Joe Schwab
Research Associate
+1-415-262-2015

DJ Sebastian
Research Associate
+1-415-262-2007

Robert Sanders
Research Analyst
+44-20-754-58394

Gianmarco Conti
Research Analyst
+44-20-754-17917

Positive fundamental outlooks from corporates differed strongly from more bearish investor sentiment

There was a notable discrepancy between management teams' outlooks for fundamentals and investors' outlooks for share prices. Fundamentally, most co's in attendance signaled steady and strong trends, especially the supply chain names gearing up for more advanced processor architectures, higher memory demand, etc. Many management teams signaled confidence not only in industry-wide trends (confidence spanned across sub-sectors like processors, broad-based semis, semicap, etc), but also company-specific efforts to expand margins and drive EPS power. By contrast, investor sentiment has soured materially from the enthusiasm seen in the first half of the year, with "peak cycle" fears common among many investors. Much of this bearishness stems from ongoing concerns of demand destruction caused by DRAM pricing and technological innovation to break through the "Memory wall".

No AI demand issue, with supply still in focus

Per our meetings and strong earnings reports last week, it's clear demand for AI compute is not slowing, with investors now assuming 2027 hyperscaler capex will reach $1.2–$1.5t, up from ~$800b in 2026. In addition, demand has broadened beyond hyperscalers alone, with neoclouds, enterprises, sovereign AI initiatives, and emerging AI labs all ramping spending and becoming an increasingly important part of the demand landscape. As such, demand is not the limiting factor; rather, memory and, to some extent, power are the primary bottlenecks. Many discussions centered around the ability to bring on supply and how the existing supply chain will evolve with next-gen processors in order to drive sustainable declines in cost per token.

Memory supply concerns at the forefront

The memory wall and ongoing supply constraints are leading customers to rethink and optimize future product roadmaps, with much investor attention focused on potential HBM de-speccing of next-gen processors, as well as the impact of higher DRAM pricing on total AI spend. In turn, this issue has also spurned competitive innovation on the inference side of things, resulting in a higher number of emerging solutions such as SRAM-heavy inference chips, custom HBM base dies, and many variations on the HBM theme (HBF, etc). This situation appears to remain highly fluid, with engineering conversations ongoing and visibility within the supply chain

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Distributed on: 31/08/2026 23:01:10 GMT

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very cloudy. Nevertheless, most management teams we spoke with believe the issue to be one of economics rather than technology, with aggregate DRAM demand likely to remain high.

Cap equipment fundamentals appear to remain robust

Concerns on memory supply have trickled in to investor sentiment on WFE spending. With higher degrees of uncertainty on total memory demand and with WFE expectations already sky-high, an increasing number of investors are wondering what is the next catalyst for the semicap group to move higher. In stark contrast to this bearish investor sentiment, fundamentals in this group appear to remain robust as ever, with new fab activity tracking in-line with expectations and setting up for strong growth in 2027/2028. Investor focus has also shifted incrementally to the margin front for these names, both on the positive side (potential for pricing tailwinds) and the negative side (capacity expansion weighing on margins).

End market stabilization/recovery continues in broad-based semis

Consistent with messaging on recent earnings calls, the broad-based semiconductor cycle is firmly on the path to recovery. Suppliers are increasingly shipping to natural demand as distributor channels clear, leading to a steady stabilization of manufacturing capacity utilization from previous cyclical lows. Within the Industrial end market, a gradual recovery is taking shape as demand in more cyclical end markets stabilizes, while more specialized secular sub-sectors continue to reach near structural highs (e.g., defense/aerospace). At the same time, data center and power infrastructure markets remain primary growth engines, driven by sustained demand for data center power solutions, as well as next-generation power upgrades (e.g., 800VDC ramping in late CY27). On the automotive front, the industry is managing a more gradual cyclical recovery with an anticipated content-driven 2H ramp, even as the adoption of advanced power architectures (e.g., 48V, SiC EV adoption) is phased gradually over the next couple of years. To support this positive long-term growth runway across end markets, mgmt teams remain focused on securing capacity and adjusting pricing structures to manage rising input costs as the cycle turns.

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Appendix 1

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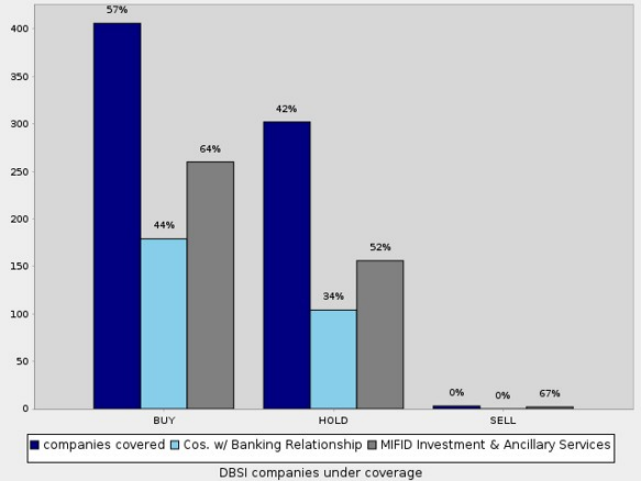
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Group Chief Economist and Global Head of Research

Pam Finelli
COO and Head of Fixed Income Research

Steve Pollard
Global Head of Company Research and Sales

Jim Reid
Global Head of Macro and Thematic Research

Tim Rokossa
Head of European Company Research

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Deutsche Bank Place
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Equity Research
Mainzer Landstrasse 11-17
60329 Frankfurt am Main
Germany
Tel: (49) 69 910 00

Deutsche Bank AG
Filiale Hongkong
International Commerce Centre,
1 Austin Road West,Kowloon,
Hong Kong
Tel: (852) 2203 8888

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1-3-1 Azabudai
Azabudai Hills Mori JP Tower
Minato-ku, Tokyo 106-0041
Japan
Tel: (81) 3 6730 1000

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London EC2Y 9DB
United Kingdom
Tel: (44) 20 7545 8000

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The Deutsche Bank Center
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Tel: (1) 212 250 2500

Deutsche Bank AG
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One Raffles Quay, South Tower,
Singapore 048583
TeL: +65 6423 8001